

31 December 1999

VLADIMIR PUTIN BECOMES ACTING PRESIDENT OF THE RUSSIAN FEDERATION

Putin took over from his predecessor Boris Yeltsin at a time of deep economic crisis. He cemented his position the following year by defeating his opponents in a presidential election, winning more than 50 per cent of the vote. Buoyed by high oil prices, the first years of his rule were a time of uninterrupted economic growth, with real incomes across the nation more than doubling. Standing again for election in 2004, Putin saw his share of the vote rise to 71 per cent.



△ Vladimir Putin (left) shakes the hand of Boris Yeltsin

17 July 1998 The International Criminal Court is established to prosecute crimes against humanity

26 August 1999 The Second Chechen War breaks out; it will end in a Russian victory

1999

24 March 1999 NATO airstrikes force the Yugoslav government to relinquish its attempts to enforce its control over Kosovo

1 July 1997 HONG KONG RETURNS TO CHINESE RULE

Hong Kong had been under British rule since 1841, with much of the territory held on a 99-year lease signed by China's imperial government in 1898. On its expiration, Britain ceded sovereignty of all Hong Kong to the People's Republic in return for a guarantee that its existing political and economic structure would be retained for 50 years. By the time of the transfer, the territory had already become a global financial hub.

◁ Hong Kong celebrates British withdrawal

